

Reading Unseen Scripts: A Zero-Real-Image Evaluation Protocol and a Scored Forecasting Campaign for Brahmic Scene Text

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Abstract

Scene-text recognition is effectively solved for Latin script and fails for most of the world’s writing systems, yet no benchmark scores the case that decides the long tail: a script for which no real labeled image exists at all. We contribute a protocol for that case and the infrastructure to audit it, rather than a new dataset. It is leave-one-script-out over nine Brahmic scripts of a public benchmark: the held-out script appears only as rendered synthetic images, never a photograph, and is read in a shared grapheme pivot space whose inverse we audit rather than assume (100.000% exact recovery on single-script labels), so pivot accuracy is target-script accuracy. An out-of-benchmark rung extends it to Khmer, a disjoint Unicode block. We release the pivot construction, the rendering pipeline, every split and result, and a harness that re-derives all 169 result numbers here and fails on mismatch; a tenth script needs only a correspondence map and a font.

Applied to a compact open vision-language model, the protocol makes every held-out script readable at 9.16–30.09% word recognition, from source-only baselines of 0.0–5.46%, and places it against three reference systems on the identical crops under the identical metric: stock per-script Tesseract, trained on real images of each target script (14.35%); a prompted 7B VLM (7.53%); and the benchmark authors’ supervised specialists (66.26%), of which we recover 29%. Swapping the pivot for a stock BPE tokenizer under identical data, seed and recipe degrades all nine scripts (sign test $p = 0.0039$), isolating output-space structure as the mechanism.

Every forecast was committed before the run it predicts, and scoring them is what makes such an apparatus informative rather than decorative: it rules things out. The preregistered primary, that tokenizer fertility predicts transfer, is falsified ($\rho = -0.80$); a filed dose-response is log-linear with a script-invariant slope but

missed its committed magnitude by $5.1\times$; Khmer, forecast before we had trained any Khmer recognizer, returned 0.8%, a -3.66σ miss that locates the method’s boundary. We advance no predictive law. We advance the protocol that refuted these claims, the infrastructure to check it, and a scored record of what it ruled out.

1. Introduction

Modern scene-text recognizers exceed 90% word accuracy on Latin benchmarks, yet most of the world’s writing systems remain unreadable to them. Recent audits are stark: across more than a hundred Unicode scripts, even frontier vision-language models (VLMs) read fewer than thirty, and on unfamiliar scripts they emit garbled or substituted output [17]. For the Brahmic family, nine major scripts used by over a billion people, real-image training data exists only because of recent, labor-intensive benchmark efforts [9, 23], and dozens of related scripts (Sinhala, Khmer, Myanmar, Tibetan, ...) have little or none. Collecting and annotating real photographs script-by-script is not a scalable path to coverage, and, crucially, no existing benchmark measures how well a recognizer does when a script’s real labeled images are absent entirely. That gap is an evaluation gap before it is a modeling one.

This paper is about closing it. We ask a question existing protocols cannot score, can a recognizer read a script for which no real labeled image exists at all?, and build the machinery to answer it honestly: a protocol isolating the zero-real-image condition, a forecasting discipline that commits every prediction before its run, and a verification chain that lets a reader re-derive every number. The protocol is leave-one-script-out (LOSO) over all nine scripts of a public real-image benchmark [9]: for each held-out script we train a source-only model (Rung A) and a source+synthetic-target model (Rung B), both evalu-

075	ated on the held-out script's real test images. A further	~15 → 15.42; Gurmukhi 16.2 filed 3.7 h pre-training	128
076	out-of-benchmark probe holds out Khmer, whose	→ 22.16; Khmer 16.1 → 0.8, a -3.66σ miss).	129
077	Unicode block and coeng-based stacking sit outside the	3. Controlled attribution of the effect — the pivot is	130
078	nine. It returns 0.8% WRR against a 16.1% forecast	the mechanism. A preregistered stock-BPE ablation	131
079	filed before we had trained one, locating the protocol's	under identical data, seed, and recipe degrades	132
080	boundary as sharply as its successes. The recognizer	WRR on all nine scripts ($1.08\times$ – $3.91\times$; sign test	133
081	exercising this machinery is a compact open	$p = 0.0039$), isolating output-space structure, not	134
082	VLM (Florence-2, 0.23B [29]) fine-tuned in a shared	synthetic fine-tuning per se, as the driver; a from-	135
083	grapheme pivot space: Brahmic scripts share an	scratch CRNN replicates the direction across an	136
084	organizational scheme (consonant bases, vowel signs,	architecture with no large-scale pretraining but not	137
085	virama-formed conjuncts), so each script's text	the magnitude, and we report the ambiguity rather	138
086	decomposes into grapheme clusters mapping by structural	than resolve it in our favor.	139
087	correspondence into one output vocabulary. The pivot	4. System analysis on the benchmark, and released	140
088	is the object the evaluation measures, not the headline	resources. On the identical test crops we situate a	141
089	claim.	prompted 7B frontier VLM (reads two of nine; loses	142
090	Our contribution class is an evaluation protocol plus	to the compact model on eight of nine), off-the-	143
091	verification infrastructure, not a data release: we	shelf per-script OCR (14.35%, which our zero-real-	144
092	collect no new photographs, instead repurposing two	image model beats on eight of nine), and the	145
093	public benchmarks [9, 25] under a new held-out	benchmark authors' own supervised specialists (66.26%,	146
094	condition and adding verified synthetic renderings. This	of which we recover 29%), giving an interpretable	147
095	is squarely what this track solicits: new evaluation	floor-to-ceiling context, alongside the released	148
096	protocols, rigorous auditing and stress-testing, and	protocol, harness and preregistration chain (Sec. 3.3).	149
097	negative results, all of which it invites independently	Auditing the benchmark's labels in passing turns up	150
098	of new datasets.	30 test items that mix two Brahmic blocks; all three	151
099	Our contributions, in the order this paper weights	systems above score 0 on them.	152
100	them:		
101	1. A zero-real-image evaluation protocol. A LOSO	2. Related Work	153
102	scene-text protocol that measures reading an entire	Multilingual STR and Indic benchmarks. STR is	154
103	writing system, disjoint Unicode block and disjoint	mature for Latin script [4] but collapses elsewhere.	155
104	glyph inventory, from zero real target images, in a	Indic-STR12 [23] and the Bharat Scene Text Dataset [9]	156
105	shared pivot space whose inverse mapping we	established real-image benchmarks for Indian	157
106	audit rather than assume (100.000% exact recovery	languages; on the latter, PARSeq reaches $\sim 47\%$	158
107	on single-script labels, so pivot-WRR equals	average WRR from synthetic data alone and $\sim 73\%$	159
108	target-script WRR), plus an out-of-benchmark	fine-tuned on real labeled images, and in-the-wild	160
109	generalization probe (Khmer). It surfaces a strong	collections keep growing the real-image supply	161
110	effect existing protocols never test: every held-out	one language at a time [28]. All of it presupposes	162
111	script moves from a $\leq 5.46\%$ source-only	labeled target data. Transfer between Indian	163
112	baseline to 9.16–30.09% WRR with zero	languages is established practice: Gunna	164
113	real target images.	et al. [13] show that transferring among	165
114	2. Prospective prediction as an evaluation	Indic scripts beats transferring from English,	166
115	practice — and a mostly negative record. A	exploiting the shared vowels and conjuncts	167
116	frozen, version-controlled preregistration	our pivot formalizes, and follow-up work	168
117	with committed-before-run forecasts, and a	adds font diversity to that recipe [12]. Both	169
118	discipline of scoring every call including	fine-tune on real images of the target	170
119	its misses. We advance no predictive	language — the target is never absent. GlotOCR	171
120	law — the record is the contribution, and	[17] measures the wider problem at scale,	172
121	it is largely one of failures. The preregistered	finding that frontier VLMs read fewer	173
122	primary (tokenizer fertility predicts transfer)	than thirty of 100+ scripts, but it	174
123	was falsified (Spearman -0.80); a	scores pretrained models on rendered	175
124	prospectively filed synthetic-exposure	text. That leaves the training-side	176
125	study gives a script-invariant, log-linear	question open: not what a model	177
126	dose-response ($+2.235$ WRR/doubling, F -test	already knows, but what it can be	178
127	$p = 0.45$) whose pre-committed	taught about a script of which	179
	magnitude missed by $5.1\times$; pivot	no real image exists. Synthetic-	
	coverage orders scripts in-sample	data engines remain Latin-centric	
	but not out-of-sample ($r = +0.03$). Every	[30], and synthetic-rendering	
	point forecast is auditable, hits and	fine-tuning has been shown for a	
	misses alike (Kannada	single low-resource script with	
		real-data validation [7]. We	
		target the regime where no	
		real labeled target image exists	

180 Tokenization granularity for complex scripts. MGP-
 181 STR [8] fuses character, BPE and WordPiece streams
 182 in one Latin recognizer; grapheme tokenization beats
 183 byte-BPE for Bengali handwriting [14]; and fertility’s
 184 value as a tokenizer metric is contested in the LLM
 185 literature [24]. A companion manuscript by the same
 186 authors [1], anonymized in the supplement, makes the
 187 supervised grapheme-vs-BPE choice predictable across
 188 nine scripts (polarity 8/9, leave-one-script-out 90.9%);
 189 the present paper shares no experiment with it, and
 190 tests, then refutes, the conjecture that the same prop-
 191 erty predicts zero-real-image transfer.

192 Unseen units vs. unseen scripts. A substantial line
 193 reads unseen characters within a known script by de-
 194 composition into shared sub-units: stroke- and radical-
 195 based zero-shot Chinese recognition [5, 31, 32] and
 196 open-set recognition of novel characters [20–22]. Zero-
 197 shot detection of unseen scripts localizes but does not
 198 read [18]. Byte-level pivots let ASR cover unseen-script
 199 languages [6], and task-arithmetic analogies achieve
 200 zero-real-data synthetic-to-real HTR for five Latin-
 201 script languages, leaving unseen writing systems ex-
 202 plicitly open [11]. To our knowledge no prior system
 203 reads real scene text of an entirely unseen script — dif-
 204 ferent Unicode block, different glyphs — from zero real
 205 target images.

206 What predicts cross-lingual transfer. In NLP, trans-
 207 fer tracks lexical and subword overlap rather than
 208 language relatedness [10, 26]. For STR specifically,
 209 Ref. [2] concludes that source dataset size and visual
 210 similarity, not linguistic typology, drive cross-lingual
 211 transfer. Our findings sharpen rather than contra-
 212 dict this, in a regime that work did not study (zero
 213 real target images): (i) a typology-adjacent structural
 214 property, fertility, indeed fails as a transfer predictor
 215 ($\rho = -0.80$), as a data-centric view expects; (ii) syn-
 216 thetic target exposure dominates, which is a target-side
 217 data-size effect; (iii) within a fixed budget, coverage of
 218 the shared grapheme space orders transfer ($\rho = +0.61$
 219 among equal-budget scripts), an OCR instantiation
 220 of the subword-overlap principle in a designed output
 221 space; and (iv) a frozen-encoder visual-similarity con-
 222 trol predicts nothing in our data ($\rho = -0.12$). Because
 223 LOSO balances source data by construction, the con-
 224 found identified by [2] is controlled by design.

225 Prediction and preregistration in empirical ML. Scal-
 226 ing laws make supervised STR predictable in model
 227 and data size [27]; preregistration and negative-result
 228 reporting are the reproducibility literature’s recom-
 229 mended remedies for HARKing and cherry-picking [15,

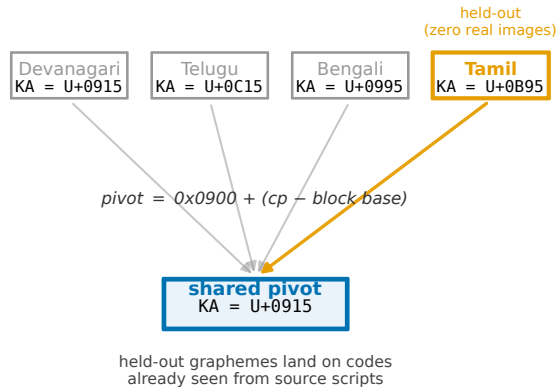


Figure 1. The shared grapheme pivot space. Each Brahmic script maps bijectively into a common output space by ISCII-derived Unicode-offset correspondence (the same letter sits at the same offset within each block); grapheme clusters in that space form the recognizer’s output vocabulary. A held-out script’s graphemes therefore land on pivot codes already seen from the source scripts. The held-out script enters training only as verified synthetic renderings (Rung B) or not at all (Rung A); evaluation is always on its real scene images.

16], yet full-study adoption is rare. We run the entire
 campaign under such a preregistration and score every
 forecast it filed.

3. Method

3.1. A shared grapheme pivot space for Brahmic scripts

Brahmic scripts encode the same phonological skeleton
 (consonant bases, dependent vowel signs, and conjunct
 formation through a virama), and Unicode preserves
 this: corresponding letters sit at the same offset within
 each script’s block. We exploit both layers.

Structural pivot. A mapping π sends any Brahmic
 codepoint to a pivot codepoint by its within-block off-
 set (Fig. 1; $\pi(c) = 0x0900 + (c - \text{base}(c))$); anything
 outside the Brahmic blocks (Latin, ASCII digits, punc-
 tuation, zero-width joiners) passes through untouched.
 Two script-neutral marks encoded inside the Devana-
 gari block, the danda and double danda, also pass
 through unshifted, since their offsets are unassigned
 in every other Brahmic block and cannot collide. The
 OM and abbreviation signs deliberately do not get that
 treatment: their offsets carry real letters elsewhere (As-
 samese RA, Gurmukhi TIPPI), so they are shifted like
 any other letter. Because π is a per-script bijective
 shift, it is exactly invertible: a hypothesis decoded in

255 pivot space is read back into the target script determin-
256 istically. Text from nine scripts thereby writes into one
257 label space in which structurally corresponding syllab-
258 les become identical strings.

259 The round trip, measured. Invertibility is a property
260 of the construction, so we checked it against the data
261 rather than asserting it. Mapping all 16178 scored test
262 labels into pivot space and back recovers 99.955% of
263 characters and 99.815% of words; on labels written
264 wholly in the script they are filed under, recovery is
265 100.000% for all nine. The whole residual is 30 labels
266 (0.19%, 17 of them Gurmukhi) mixing two Brahmic
267 blocks: 7 words typed in the wrong script, and 23 where
268 a homoglyph was substituted inside a correct one, such
269 as a Devanagari digit for its Gujarati twin. These are
270 benchmark annotation faults, invisible in the rendered
271 image, and they are unwinnable under exact match
272 rather than merely hard: our Rung B, the Tesseract
273 floor and the supervised PARSeq ceiling each score 0
274 of 30 on them. We leave them in and count them as
275 errors, keeping our numbers conservative and compa-
276 rable with published ones.

277 Grapheme-cluster vocabulary. Within pivot space
278 we segment text into grapheme clusters (consonant-
279 virama conjuncts kept whole, dependent signs at-
280 tached) and inject the resulting cluster inventory (1624
281 types for the source pool) as dedicated tokens into
282 the recognizer’s tokenizer. The alternative, letting the
283 stock byte-BPE tokenizer segment pivot-space text, is
284 the ablation of Sec. 4: it sees the same pivot strings but
285 fragments clusters into sub-syllabic pieces. Fertility
286 (mean clusters per word) governs when grapheme tok-
287 enization beats BPE in supervised training: in a 12-run
288 balanced-budget study across the same nine scripts,
289 fertility predicts the winning branch with 8/9 polar-
290 ity and 90.9% leave-one-script-out direction accuracy
291 ($R^2=0.678$). That result motivates both the pivot de-
292 sign and the (ultimately falsified) primary hypothesis
293 of Sec. 5.

294 3.2. Zero-real-image protocol

295 For each held-out script S of the nine in the bench-
296 mark [9]:

297 Sources. All benchmark languages whose script is
298 not S (languages sharing S , e.g. Assamese for Bengali
299 script, are excluded, so S is genuinely unseen). Each
300 source language contributes exactly 700 train / 90 val
301 real images (seed 42), giving balanced source exposure
302 by construction. Source-side data size is therefore con-
303 trolled, unlike prior cross-lingual STR studies [2].

Synthetic target. 3240 images per target language: 304
benchmark-vocabulary words rendered in fontconfig- 305
verified fonts (multiple faces per script, libraqm shap- 306
ing), each render checked non-blank, and the rendered 307
word enters training as its pivot transcription. No real 308
photograph of S is ever seen. Scripts written by two 309
source languages receive two languages’ worth of ren- 310
derings ($2\times$ budget), a covariate disclosed at preregis- 311
tration time that becomes central in Sec. 5. 312

Rungs. Rung A trains on sources only. Rung B adds 313
the synthetic target set, and Rung B_{bpe} repeats Rung B 314
with the grapheme-cluster injection removed (stock to- 315
kenizer), identical data, seed, and recipe. All rungs 316
fine-tune Florence-2 (0.23B) [29] with LoRA ($r=16$, 317
 $\alpha=32$, dropout 0.05), lr 10^{-4} , batch size 4, 15 epochs, 318
validation-selected checkpoint, beam-search decoding 319
at test. 320

Evaluation. The held-out script’s real test split, WRR 321
= exact match after NFC normalization, zero-width- 322
character removal, and whitespace collapse, which is 323
the benchmark’s own protocol [9, 23], plus character 324
accuracy ($1 - \text{CER}$). 325

326 3.3. Preregistration and prospective predictions

The campaign ran under a frozen preregistration with 327
an append-only amendment log — every amendment 328
was filed before the results it concerns existed. Descrip- 329
tors entering the transfer horse-race were computed 330
result-blind: fertility and pivot coverage before any 331
Rung-B result, and a frozen-encoder visual-similarity 332
control before the third. Quantitative forecasts for 333
later runs were committed and pushed to a version- 334
controlled archive before those runs trained, and are 335
scored against a rule fixed at filing time, hits and misses 336
alike (Sec. 5). We state the limit of this plainly, be- 337
cause it is the weakest link in the design. The archive is 338
a version-controlled repository that was private during 339
the campaign: no third party observed the commits as 340
they were made, and git’s own timestamps are settable 341
by the author. The supplement ships the filed docu- 342
ments under SHA-256, which establishes that they are 343
unaltered — not when they were written. Filing order 344
is therefore attested rather than proven, and we do not 345
present it as proven. 346

What survives that limit is worth separating from 347
what does not. Every scoring rule, band and point 348
value is in the supplement and checkable against the 349
results, so a reader can confirm each forecast is scored 350
by the rule filed with it rather than one chosen later. 351
The shape of the record is itself evidence: documents 352
written after the fact would not have produced a fal- 353
sified primary hypothesis, a $5.1\times$ magnitude miss and 354
a -3.66σ out-of-block miss. Backdating buys hits, not 355

this. The forecasts are genuine. Their timing is unwitting.

The general lesson is a protocol one, and it may be the more useful contribution. A campaign can be run honestly and still end up unverifiable, which is the exact failure this apparatus exists to prevent. Anchor each filing, as it is filed, in a timestamp no author controls: an anonymized public preregistration, or a hash on an append-only ledger. Ours predates that decision. Anyone building on this protocol should not repeat it.

Released resources. We release the apparatus, not a description of it: the pivot construction and its 1624-type grapheme vocabulary; the verified rendering pipeline; every LOSO split actually used (nine scripts $\times$ rungs A/B/B_{bpe}, plus the Khmer rungs); every per-run result file the paper cites, anchors included; the preregistration chain with each forecast and its scoring receipt; and `verify_wacv_numbers.py`, which rederives every derivable number in this paper from those result files and exits non-zero on any mismatch (169 macros, zero mismatches at submission). Extending the protocol to a tenth script needs only a correspondence map and a font; the Khmer rung is the worked example, and the harness is unchanged.

4. Experiments

Our comparisons are the source-only baseline (Rung A), the raw pre-trained VLM (WRR 0.0), the stock-BPE ablation, the reference systems of Sec. 4.2, and our own forecasts.

4.1. Main result: every unseen script becomes readable

Every one of the nine moves from a near-floor source-only baseline (0.0–5.46% WRR; the raw pre-trained model reads none of them) to 9.16–30.09% WRR at 34.57–57.77% character accuracy, without a single real target image. Transfer holds even where there is least to borrow: Malayalam has the lowest pivot coverage (79.2%) and still goes 0.18→9.69. Rung A tracks incidental pivot-space coverage, highest for Devanagari, so the pivot shares structure before any target exposure.

4.2. Floor and ceiling

Absolute numbers need a scale, and the supervised ceiling alone is the wrong one. Against the ceiling we recover 0.29 of the macro-average (19.41% vs. 66.26%): real labels remain worth roughly 3.4 $\times$ what our synthetic pivot buys, and we do not present that as close. Against the floor the picture inverts. Stock Tesseract ships a per-script model for every script here, trained

Script	<i>N</i>	A	B	B 95% CI	CharAcc	B _{bpe}
Tamil	513	0.0	9.16	[6.6, 11.7]	39.0	2.34
Telugu	545	1.28	19.82	[16.5, 23.1]	54.43	10.28
Kannada	720	2.78	15.42	[12.8, 18.1]	46.37	13.33
Malayalam	547	0.18	9.69	[7.3, 12.2]	34.57	4.2
Oriya	1044	0.77	25.38	[22.7, 28.1]	56.37	14.94
Gujarati	1015	3.05	15.86	[13.6, 18.2]	38.49	13.69
Bengali	2873	1.39	27.08	[25.5, 28.7]	57.77	19.07
Devanagari	6042	5.46	30.09	[28.9, 31.3]	57.16	27.99
Gurmukhi	2879	0.59	22.16	[20.7, 23.7]	44.1	17.65
macro-average			19.41			

Table 1. Zero-real-image transfer across nine held-out Brahmic scripts (real test images). Rung A: source scripts only. Rung B: + synthetic target renderings, zero real target images (95% CI = percentile bootstrap over test samples, 5000 resamples). B_{bpe}: Rung B with the grapheme-cluster vocabulary removed (stock tokenizer), identical data and seed. On 6/9 scripts the Rung-B CI lies strictly above the B_{bpe} 95% CI. Reference systems on these same crops are in Table 2.

Script	Tess.	Qwen	Rung B	PARSeq	o/c
Tamil	15.4	6.24	9.16	76.61	0.12
Telugu	13.76	0.18	19.82	55.78	0.36
Kannada	12.08	0.28	15.42	59.44	0.26
Malayalam	5.85	0.0	9.69	64.53	0.15
Oriya	15.52	0.38	25.38	67.62	0.38
Gujarati	12.41	0.3	15.86	57.04	0.28
Bengali	15.32	24.82	27.08	72.82	0.37
Devanagari	19.78	35.05	30.09	68.9	0.44
Gurmukhi	19.03	0.52	22.16	73.6	0.30
macro-avg	14.35	7.53	19.41	66.26	0.29

Table 2. Every reference system on the identical crops, through the identical pivot mapping and exact-match metric. Tess. — stock per-script Tesseract 5, trained on real labeled images of each target script (off-the-shelf floor). Qwen — Qwen2.5-VL-7B prompted zero-shot, scored under the disclosed most-favorable extraction. PARSeq — the benchmark authors’ own supervised specialists, also trained on real labeled target images; BSTD train and test share no source image on any script, and the measured mean is in line with the $\sim 73\%$ they report. o/c = ours / ceiling. Both trained-on-real systems presuppose exactly the data whose absence defines our setting.

on real target images, and is what a practitioner deploys today: it reaches 14.35%, and our zero-real-image model is ahead by +5.06 points on macro-average, losing only Tamil. It is a document engine outside its design domain, so this is no claim to be the better recognizer, only evidence that the zero-real-image regime has passed what is obtainable off the shelf.

4.3. The pivot is the mechanism: BPE ablation

Removing the grapheme-cluster vocabulary, with the same pivot strings, images and seed, degrades all nine scripts (Table 1), from $1.08\times$ (Devanagari, $30.09 \rightarrow 27.99$ WRR) to $3.91\times$ (Tamil, $9.16 \rightarrow 2.34$). The margin varies, the direction never does (exact two-sided sign test, $p = 0.0039$). The bootstrap makes the per-script margin concrete: on 6/9 scripts the Rung-B 95% CI clears the B_{bpe} interval outright (Table 1); the three exceptions, Devanagari, Kannada and Gujarati, are exactly the near-parity scripts ($1.08\text{--}1.16\times$) — consistent with the direction holding but the magnitude shrinking as fertility falls. The character-accuracy pattern is diagnostic: on Telugu, Kannada and Devanagari the BPE model equals or exceeds the pivot model’s character accuracy (Telugu 55.1% vs. 54.43%), yet word accuracy drops in every case. Synthetic fine-tuning alone teaches the model to see the characters. The cluster-level output space is what assembles them into correct whole words.

4.4. Dose–response: synthetic budget

We hold the recipe fixed and vary only the number of synthetic target images, for the three scripts whose held-out budget we can grow (Malayalam, Kannada, Telugu) across $\{810, 1620, 6480, 12960\}$ renderings; the external Rung-B point (3240) anchors each curve. Word recognition is cleanly log-linear in synthetic exposure (R^2 from 0.905 to 0.999 per script), and the slope is script-invariant: a single shared $+2.235$ WRR per doubling fits all three, with no evidence of differing slopes (F -test $p = 0.45$; Fig. 2). This is the preregistered form, and it holds.

The preregistered magnitude does not. The frozen instrument projected $+11.48$ WRR per doubling, transported from the in-script $2\times$ -synthetic experiment that fit the two-factor model (Sec. 5). The swept slope excludes that by a factor of 5.1, with the faithful doubling step ($3240 \rightarrow 6480$) gaining $+2.35$ WRR against a predicted $+11.5$, outside the ± 2 RMSE band and reported as filed (open squares, Fig. 2). Two further preregistered edges resolve the same way: the low-budget prediction of near-collapse toward the Rung-A floor is falsified (Kannada and Telugu already reach double digits at 810 images, so transfer is concave in log-budget), and the top step ($6480 \rightarrow 12960$), which adds renderings at near-fixed lexicon, gains little on Kannada but keeps pace on Malayalam and Telugu. Synthetic scaling is real and orderly, then, but far shallower than an in-script extrapolation predicts. We do not promote pivot-space coverage to a cross-script driver: it orders the three swept scripts in-sample, but across the six never used in the fit it is uncorrelated with

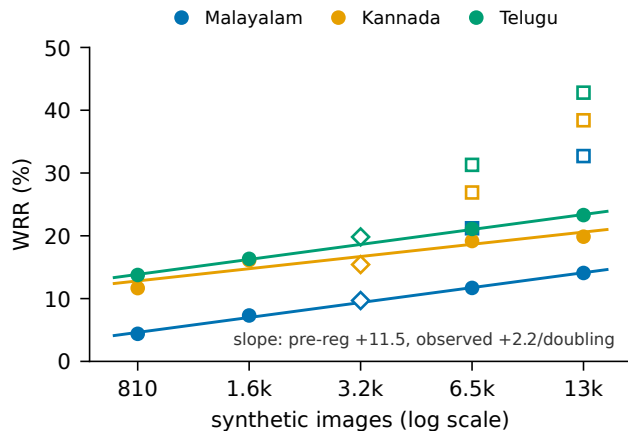


Figure 2. Synthetic-budget dose-response for three held-out scripts. Filled circles: observed WRR on real test images; solid lines: per-script log-linear fits (shared slope $+2.235/\text{doubling}$); open diamonds: the external Rung-B anchor (3240 images); open squares: the preregistered point predictions — their gap above the observed points is the $5.1\times$ magnitude miss, reported as filed.

transfer ($r = +0.03$).

4.5. Architecture generality: a preregistered CRNN replication

Every result above uses one backbone, inviting the objection that the effect is specific to a pretrained vision-language model. We preregistered a replication (Amendment 6, committed before any CRNN trained) on a from-scratch CRNN (ResNet+BiLSTM, CTC, no large-scale pretraining) over the same LOSO splits, pivot space and metric, for the three equal-synthetic scripts spanning the observed Rung-B range (Tamil, Telugu, Oriya), vocabulary from TRAIN records only and a 60-epoch budget fixed in advance. Four predictions were filed; all four are scored.

The two structural predictions hold: source-only Rung A stays at the floor on all three ($\text{WRR} \leq 0.67$, predicted < 2.0), and the held-out ranking is preserved ($0.97 < 1.1 < 4.5$, matching the Florence-2 order), with Rung B above Rung A everywhere. The two effect-size predictions miss. The preregistered primary, a $\geq +2.0$ WRR lift on at least two of three, holds only on Oriya ($+3.83$). The CRNN reaches a $0.11\times$ fraction of the Florence-2 transfer level on average (predicted band $[0.15, 0.60]$), inside the band on Oriya alone, and character accuracy is depressed in step (Tamil 25.09% vs. 39.0%): the small model sees fewer characters, not merely fewer whole words. Per the preregistration’s declared caveat we call this ambiguous rather than resolve it in our favour: an attenuated directional replication fits both a backbone-dependent mechanism and a plain

capacity floor, and the character accuracy supports the latter. The direction replicates across architectures; the magnitude stays open.

4.6. Out-of-benchmark: Khmer

Every script above shares the ISCII-aligned Brahmic design the pivot was built around, so to find where the method stops we ran it somewhere it should struggle: Khmer, a disjoint Unicode block with coeng-based stacking, outside the benchmark and outside India. Reaching it needed a hand-curated pivot extension (94.41% of test codepoints map; the rest are approximated or dropped and counted as misses). Under Amendment 4b, Rung A trains on the nine benchmark scripts with no Khmer of any kind and Rung B adds 3240 synthetic Khmer words, still with no real Khmer image; both are evaluated on 1252 KhmerST [25] word crops. Khmer recognition is an active area, but its systems train on real Khmer [19], exactly the data this rung withholds. Before any Khmer recognizer of ours existed we filed a point prediction from the frozen two-factor model, 16.1 WRR at ± 1 -RMSE [11.9, 20.3], with a written caveat that we expected it to be fragile.

It was. Rung B reaches 0.8% WRR against a predicted 16.1: a residual of -15.3, or -3.66 -RMSE, below even the ± 2 -RMSE band [7.8, 24.5]. The miss is not an artifact of the coverage recheck disclosed at build time: re-evaluating the same instrument at the realized token coverage (88.01% rather than the filed 89.02%) moves the point only to 15.52. Only the structural prediction survives: Rung A sits at 0.0 (predicted < 5). The instrument had already lost its slope magnitude in block (Sec. 4.4); this is the first script we asked it to predict outside the blocks it was fit on, and it failed there too. We do not carry it forward as a contribution.

Two things nonetheless hold. The direction replicates (+0.8 WRR, +5.85 character accuracy over the no-target-data control), so the mechanism is not inert out of block; the magnitude collapses to 4.1% of the nine-script Rung-B mean. For calibration, stock Tesseract’s Khmer-specific model, trained on real Khmer and scored on the identical crops, reaches only 2.16% here against 14.35% across the nine: these crops are hard for a supervised system too. That is context, not a rescue. Both numbers sit near the floor, and 0.8% is a failure to transfer usefully.

We draw the boundary claim narrowly. Khmer received the same $1\times$ synthetic budget and comparable nominal token coverage (88.01%) that yield double-digit WRR in block, and still returned 0.8. Volume and coverage were held up; typological proximity was not; the transfer collapsed. That is the cleanest evidence we have that relatedness, not synthetic volume,

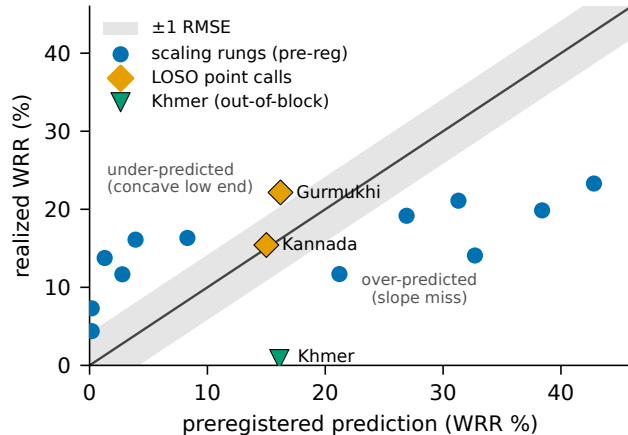


Figure 3. Prospective scorecard: preregistered prediction vs. realized WRR for every quantitative forecast filed before its run, scored against the rule fixed at filing time (shaded ± 1 RMSE). The in-block LOSO point calls land on the diagonal; the scaling rungs fall off it both ways — under-predicted at low budget, over-predicted at high. Khmer, the out-of-block call, misses low by -3.66 -RMSE. Hits and misses are both shown.

carries the effect, but it is a single script, and we state it as suggestive rather than decisive.

4.7. Frontier-VLM reference

We prompt Qwen2.5-VL-7B [3] zero-shot on the same nine real test sets (fixed prompt, greedy decoding), preregistered under Amendment 4c. Under the declared primary metric, exact word match on the raw generation, it scores 0.0% on all nine, because the chat model wraps every answer in prose (“The text in the image is ...”). We therefore report a disclosed, most-favorable re-score (Table 2): the first quoted span from each generation, under the identical metric. Even so the VLM reads only the two highest-resource scripts with any competence (Bengali 24.82%, Devanagari 35.05%), sits at or near zero on six of the remaining seven, and often returns a wholly different script: Gurumukhi in Devanagari, Malayalam in Bengali. Our compact pivot model leads on eight of nine at a fraction of the parameters. This is one open model under one prompt and the comparison is not like-for-like, its training data being unknown; the broader audit of [17], over 100+ scripts and many models, is the load-bearing evidence that scale alone does not read these scripts.

5. What Predicts Transfer?

We report the confirmatory analysis exactly as preregistered, our own primary hypothesis included.

5.1. The preregistered primary fails

Fertility, the property that governs the supervised grapheme-vs-BPE trade-off (Sec. 3.1), was preregistered as the primary transfer predictor (H3). It is refuted: Spearman $\rho = -0.80$ across the nine Rung-B results, directionally opposite to the hypothesis. The flagship case was called in advance by the declared competitor: our prospective prediction file ranked Malayalam best under fertility (P1) and worst under coverage (P2); it realized bottom-tier (9.69 WRR). We report this as a genuine falsification, consistent with fertility skepticism in the LLM-tokenizer literature [24] and with the data-centric view of STR transfer [2].

Post-hoc, fertility instead tracks who needs the pivot: BPE comes closest to parity on the lowest-fertility script and collapses on the highest ($1.08\times$ Devanagari, $3.91\times$ Tamil). That is unregistered, $n = 9$, and used for nothing here.

5.2. The two-factor account

Two result-blind quantities describe the campaign and generated its forecasts; we state them as description, not inference, because at $n = 9$ scripts nothing here carries appreciable inferential force. Synthetic budget dominates: the two scripts with the disclosed $2\times$ budget (Bengali, Devanagari) are the top two results (27.08, 30.09 WRR), Bengali from the second-lowest coverage. Coverage orders the seven equal-budget scripts ($\rho = +0.61$). The joint fit $\text{WRR} = -35.79 + 0.583 \cdot \text{cov} + 11.48 \cdot \mathcal{K}[2\times]$ (RMSE 4.18 WRR) is the instrument every later forecast was drawn from, so we print it for audit, and then discount it ourselves: a script-level bootstrap puts its coverage slope at $[-0.48, 3.49]$, spanning zero, and that term fails out-of-sample outright ($r = +0.03$, Sec. 4.4). Coverage is an in-sample ordering and nothing more. One control stands on its own: rendered glyphs embedded by the recognizer’s own frozen vision encoder predict transfer not at all ($\rho = -0.12$), separating whatever the ordering reflects from the visual-similarity account of [2].

5.3. Prospective scorecard

Four forecasts were filed before their runs and all four are scored in Fig. 3. Two are in-block point calls: Kannada (~ 15 WRR, filed with two scripts observed, realized 15.42) and Gurmukhi, the final script (16.2 WRR with $\pm 1\sigma$ [12.2, 20.2], committed and pushed 3.7 hours before training began, realized 22.16, under-called by 1.5σ but inside $\pm 2\sigma$). A third, Devanagari, was a directional call committed before the result existed but pushed after; it is only weakly prospective and we lean on it for nothing. The fourth is Khmer (Sec. 4.6), the one call filed outside the pivot’s Unicode blocks, which

missed by -3.66σ . The declared rank bet between the two preregistered predictors resolved for coverage over fertility, neither ranking alone significant at $n = 7$.

The summary is bounded: in-block, transfer is forecastable to roughly ± 4.18 WRR (1σ) from two pre-training quantities, but the instrument missed out of block and we decline to extend it past the blocks it was fit on: one script shows it failed there, not that it must fail everywhere outside.

6. Limitations

Absolute accuracy. Our macro-average (19.41%) clears the off-the-shelf OCR floor (14.35%), though the weakest script does not: Tamil (9.16%) falls below it, and all nine sit far under the supervised ceiling ($\sim 73\%$ with real labels [9]). The synthetic $\rightarrow$ real domain gap is the dominant residual: training loss reaches ~ 0.06 while real-image WRR stays modest. The target script must be known. π^{-1} resolves a pivot string into one script, so the protocol assumes script identity is fixed before decoding. That is given for a held-out-script benchmark, and an extra component for mixed-script scenes. One family, and a located boundary. Nine scripts, one benchmark, one family whose shared structure the pivot exploits by design; Khmer (Sec. 4.6) shows the method failing outside it (0.8% WRR). One architecture. All transfer results use Florence-2; a from-scratch CRNN replicates the direction at ~ 0.11 of the magnitude (Sec. 4.5), so backbone-independence of the effect size is untested. Model imperfections. Gujarati underperforms its coverage, one Rung-A baseline breaches the predicted < 5 line (Devanagari, 5.46), and the final-script forecast under-called by 1.5σ ; all reported, none explained away. Compute. One 24 GB GPU; budgets were fixed by preregistration, not tuned.

7. Conclusion

We built an evaluation protocol for a condition existing benchmarks do not score, a script with no real labeled image at all, and ran a forecasting campaign inside it. Under it, a small open VLM fine-tuned in a shared grapheme pivot space on rendered synthetic text alone reads real photographs of all nine unseen Brahmic scripts at 9.16–30.09% word accuracy, and a stock-BPE ablation collapses that transfer, isolating output-space structure as the mechanism. The forecasting record is mostly one of misses: primary hypothesis falsified, scaling magnitude missed by $5.1\times$, coverage failing out-of-sample, the one out-of-block call (Khmer) missed by -3.66σ . We advance no predictive law. Every call ships in the supplement with its receipt, and the failures locate the method’s boundary rather than leave it for someone else to find.

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